Seven Ships of the Enemy — Player's Manual

First draft, 25 October 2026; brought up to date 26 October 2026.

> *"My father, behold, the enemy's ships came; my cities were burned, and they did evil things in my country. Does not my father know that all my troops and chariots are in the land of Hatti, and all my ships are in the land of Lukka? … Seven ships of the enemy came, and they did great damage."*
>
> — Ammurapi, last king of Ugarit, to the king of Alashiya, about 1185 BC

1. The setting

The eastern Mediterranean, 1600 BC. Four great powers share the coasts and the river valleys between Greece and the Nile: palace kingdoms that trade copper, tin, cedar, wine and purple dye with each other, write to each other as brothers, and go to war when the letters turn cold.

You lead one of them for four hundred years, from the rise of the palaces to the end of the Bronze Age. Around 1200 BC the world they built breaks apart: raiders come from the sea, the trade routes fail, droughts and earthquakes strike, and kingdoms that seemed eternal fall into ruin. **The game is about what you build before that, and what survives it.**

It plays like *Civilization*: you found cities, work the land around them, build units, explore, trade, fight and make peace, turn by turn, on a map of hexagons.

The four peoples

People	Ruler	Starts near	Advantage
Mycenaeans	Agamemnon, Wanax of Mycenae	wine or olives	Ships cost a quarter less
Hittites	Suppiluliuma, Great King of Hatti	copper	Chariots cost a quarter less
Egyptians	Thutmose III, King of Egypt	grain	Cities need a quarter less food to grow
Canaanites	Niqmaddu II, King of Ugarit	cedar or purple dye	Buying production costs a third less (mercenaries), and each trade deal brings a gold more

You choose one; the computer leads the other three. Every people is in every game. There are also **barbarians**, who own no kingdom but raid everybody, and late in the game the **Sea Peoples**. Help → Peoples has a page on each people, and one on the barbarians and the Sea Peoples.

2. Starting a game

The title screen offers **Start Game**, **Load Saved Game** and **Quit**. Start Game asks for your people, then the difficulty level:

Level	What the computer players pay for what they build and for their cities' growth	Barbarians
Scribe	150% (and you start with 50 gold)	rare, small bands
Governor	120%	occasional
Prince	100% — a fair contest	occasional
King	80%	frequent
Great King	70%	frequent, large bands

On harder levels the computer players also think less well of you, and anger more easily.

You begin with a **settler** and a **warrior**. Found your first city quickly: press **b** with the settler.

3. The screen

- **The map** takes most of the screen. Unexplored land is black until one of your units or cities comes near it.
- **The minimap**, top left, shows the whole world; the white frame is the part you are looking at. Click it to jump there.
- **The panel**, down the left, shows your people, the year, the turn, your gold, the unit waiting for orders and its moves left, and messages.
- **The readout**, top right, names whatever is under the pointer: the terrain, its resource and improvements, what it yields (food/shields/ trade), and its position — or the unit or city on it.
- **The menu bar**, top: Game, Orders, Advisors, World, Help.

The world wraps east to west, but not north to south.

4. Controls

Everything can be done from the keyboard; a mouse or joystick moves the pointer, and the button acts as a click.

Moving and orders

Key	Action
Tab	Tile select: a ring on the unit; the cursor keys move it, Return moves the unit there (or acts on that hexagon)
click	Next to the unit: move there (onto an enemy: attack; onto your galley: board)
g	Go to: pick a hexagon with the ring or a click, and the unit walks there over the coming turns
b	Found a city (settler); found an emporium (merchant ship)
f	Fortify (a galley on a merchant ship's hexagon escorts it)
i	Irrigate (builder); fish (fishing boat on fish)
m	Build a mine (builder)
p	Build a pasture on cattle or horses (builder)
r	Build a road (builder)
w	Wait: ask again after the other units

Key	Action
space	Skip this unit's turn
c	Centre the map on the unit (and, in tile select, the ring)
Return	End the turn (when the panel asks)

The map and the game

Key	Action
cursor keys	Scroll the map
click	On a city of yours: the city screen. On a unit of yours: give it the orders. Elsewhere: centre the map there
F1 – F4	The advisors: Cities, Military, Diplomacy, Finance
MEGA + letter	Open a menu (MEGA+G for Game, and so on)
HELP	The list of keys
Esc	Quit to BASIC (after asking)

In the xemu emulator, HELP is on **PageUp**, MEGA is the left **Alt** key, and the keypad's 7 9 4 6 1 3 move the unit.

By default the turn ends by itself once every unit has had its orders; Game → Options → End of Turn makes it wait for Return instead.

5. Cities

A settler founds a city where it stands (**b**). A city stands on a road, and is the centre of its **reach**: its own hexagon and two rings around it, 19 hexagons. Where the reaches of two cities overlap, a hexagon belongs to the nearer city, so cities founded close together share their land; the computer players keep theirs four hexagons apart.

Citizens and growth

A city of size n works its own hexagon and n hexagons of its reach, the best ones, unless you choose them yourself on the city screen. **Each citizen eats 2 food.** What is left over goes into the food box; when the box is full ($10 \times (\text{size} + 1)$) the city grows, and when it is empty and still short of food, the city shrinks. Without irrigation, most cities stop growing where the land can feed no more.

Production

The **shields** of the worked hexagons go towards whatever the city is building. When there are enough, the unit appears in the city, or the building is put up. A **settler takes a citizen** with it, so it waits until the city is size 2.

The city screen

Click one of your cities (or Return on it in tile select) to open it:

- **Left**: the units in the city. Click one, or press its number, to wake it (or to fortify it).
- **Middle**: the city and its reach. A yellow ring marks a worked hexagon. Click a hexagon (or move to it with the cursor keys and press space) to take a citizen off it or put an idle one on it.

- **Below**: size, food, shields, trade, how soon it grows, its wonders.
- **Right**: what it is producing. **CHANGE** (c) lists what it can build; **BUY** (b) finishes it at the end of the turn for gold. Under them, the city's buildings.

Advisors → Cities (F1) lists all your cities; pick one to open it.

6. The land

Terrain

Terrain	Food	Shields	Trade	Defence
Grassland	2	0 (half of it 1)	0	
Plains	1	1	0	
Floodplain	3	0 (half of it 1)	1	
Forest	1	2	0	×1.5
Hills	1	0	0	×1.5
Mountains	0	1	0	×2
Desert	0	1	0	
Tundra	1	0	0	
Shallows	1	0	2	
Ocean	1	0	2	

The **floodplain** is the land along the rivers: the grain of the world. Help → Terrain Types has a page on each.

Resources

Resource	Where	Adds
Grain	floodplain, grassland	2 food
Fish	shallows	2 food
Cattle	grassland, plains, hills	1 food, 1 shield
Olives	hills	1 food, 2 trade
Wine	hills, plains	3 trade
Cedar	forest	2 shields
Copper	hills, mountains	2 shields
Tin	hills, mountains; and at the far north and south	1 shield
Purple dye	shallows	3 trade
Horses	grassland, plains	2 shields

A resource in the reach of a city adds to what its hexagon yields.

Your people *has* a resource when it is on one of your cities, or in a city's reach and improved the way it needs — copper and tin **mined**, cattle and horses with a **pasture**, olives and wine **irrigated** — or when you receive it in trade, or it is next to one of your emporia. Grain, fish, cedar and dye need nothing.

What you have decides what you can build:

- **Bronze** — copper *and* tin — for the **spearman**. Tin is scarce: a few hills and mountains, and the edges of the world. Most peoples have to trade for it.
- **Horses** for the **chariot**.
- **Cedar**, and a city on the coast, for the **galley**.

Improvements

Builders improve the land. A builder at work asks for no orders until it is done; several builders on one hexagon work together.

Improvement	Key	Turns	Where	Adds
Irrigation	i	5	grassland, plains, desert, floodplain, hills, next to water (the sea, a river's floodplain, other irrigation)	1 food
Mine	m	10	hills, mountains, desert; copper and tin anywhere	3 / 2 / 1 shields on hills / mountains / desert
Pasture	p	5	cattle and horses	1 food, 1 shield
Road	r	2 (4 on hills and in forest, 6 on mountains)	any land	1 trade on grassland, plains and desert

A step from road to road costs a third of a move. Every city stands on a road.

A **fishing boat** works fish: on a fish, press **i**. The boat is used up and the fish yields a food more for good.

7. Units

Unit	Attack	Defence	Moves	Cost	Needs
Settler	0	1	1	30	a city of size 2 (takes a citizen)
Warrior	1	1	1	10	
Builder	0	1	1	20	
Spearman	1	2	1	20	bronze
Chariot	4	1	2	40	horses; never onto mountains
Galley	1	1	3	40	cedar, a coastal city
Fishing boat	0	1	2	20	a coastal city
Merchant ship	0	1	3	30	a coastal city

Ships sail the **shallows** only, and their own cities. **A galley carries two land units**: step onto it to board; they are woken when it stops next to land, to step ashore. The fishing boat explores the coasts and works fish. The merchant ship carries trade and founds emporia (section 10). Help → Military Units has a page on each unit.

Go to (**g**): pick a hexagon, and the unit walks there by itself over the explored land (or a ship over the shallows), turn after turn, and asks for orders when it arrives or finds the way blocked.

Advisors → Military (F2) counts your units by kind, what they cost you, and your wars.

8. Combat

Moving onto another people's unit or city is an attack — the game asks first if it means declaring war. The attacker wins with a chance of attack against defence: a chariot (4) attacking a warrior (1) wins four times in five. The defender's strength is multiplied by its ground:

- hills and forest ×1.5, mountains ×2;
- fortified, or in a city, ×1.5;
- in the city with the Lion Gate, ×2;
- a galley fortified at sea (an escort), ×2.

The best defender on a hexagon fights. Outside a city, if it loses, every unit on the hexagon dies with it; in a city only the defender dies. **A city is taken by moving into it when nobody is left in it**; barbarians burn it instead.

Every fight you are in is shown to you, with the map on it.

9. Diplomacy

You **meet** a people when one of your units or cities comes next to one of theirs. The rulers then write to you, in the words of the Amarna letters: *"Say to Agamemnon, Wanax of Mycenae, my brother: thus says Suppiluliuma, Great King of Hatti, your brother. . . "*

Between any two peoples there is **war**, a **ceasefire** (16 turns, then war again unless peace is made), or **peace**. Every people starts at peace with every other, and at war with the barbarians.

Each ruler has an **attitude** to you — hostile, cold, wary, cordial, friendly — which drifts back to its temper over time, and which you change: wars declared on it or on its friends, your units by its cities, your cities crowding its own, refused offers and tribute all make it colder; peace and trade make it warmer. A cold and strong ruler declares war; one losing a war asks for a ceasefire; one at ceasefire and friendly offers peace. Letters asking something are answered **Yes** or **No**.

Advisors → Diplomacy (F3) lists every people: how you stand, its ruler, its cities and army, its attitude and its wars and trade. Choose a people with the cursor keys, then:

Key	Proposal
C	a ceasefire (at war)
P	peace (in a ceasefire)
W	declare war
T	trade, or end a trade (at peace)
S	demand submission (at war)

Vassals

A people at war that is losing badly — weaker than its enemy, with half its cities or fewer — may **submit** rather than fight on, in the vassals' formula: *"At the feet of my lord I fall, seven times and seven times."* You can accept, or demand it yourself (S). A vassal is at peace with its lord, pays it **an eighth of its gold every turn** as tribute, and counts for its lord's score. It goes free when it grows stronger than its lord, or its lord falls. You are never anybody's vassal.

10. Trade

Goods and deals

The trade goods are **olives, wine, cedar, copper, tin, purple dye and horses**. A **deal** is one good sent for another, between two peoples at peace, or a gift. A good is not used up by sending it, and **a good received counts as had** — traded tin and your own copper make bronze. Partners think better of each other, and each deal brings both of them gold every turn.

Rulers write to ask for trades, and strong, cold ones demand goods as tribute. You propose a trade on the Diplomacy screen (T).

Merchant fleets

A deal lapses 40 turns after the last merchant ship came — unless the two peoples have cities within 8 hexagons of each other, and trade over land. To keep a deal alive, load a merchant ship in one of your cities and sail it next to (or into) a city of your partner's. Raiders and enemies sink merchant ships, so **escort them**: a galley fortified (**f**) on the merchant ship's hexagon goes where it goes and defends it twice as well.

Emporia

A merchant ship can also found an **emporium** (**b**): a trading post on a foreign coast, next to the ship, by trade goods, at least two hexagons from any city. The ship is used up. **Your people owns the goods on the six hexagons around it** — tin and copper for bronze, cedar for galleys, the rest for trade and score. An enemy standing on an emporium at the end of a turn burns it.

11. The treasury

Every turn, **each city's trade, less its corruption, goes into your gold**, and your trade deals add more. Corruption grows with the distance from your capital (your first city); without a capital, almost all the trade is lost.

What you pay:

- **the upkeep of your city buildings**: 1 gold a turn for a temple or an edubba, 2 for a feasting hall, nothing for a stele (short of gold, a building is sold);
- **1 gold a turn for each unit** beyond the free ones: 4, and 3 more for each city (short of gold, a unit is disbanded);
- **a growing cost for a realm of more than 10 cities**;
- **your scribes** (below).

Gold buys production: BUY on the city screen finishes it at the end of the turn. The price rises steeply for more shields, and is doubled if nothing has been built towards it yet.

Advisors → Finance (F4) shows it all, city by city.

Scribes and the clay tablets

On the Finance screen, **+ and -** set what you pay your **scribes** each turn. Each gold paid is a point of **knowledge** — and each edubba (section 12) adds a point a turn and a fifth of the pay more — and at 100, 300 and 600 points your scribes set down, in turn:

Tablet	Knowledge	Effect
Linear B	100	Your cities lose a quarter less to corruption
A law code	300	Five more cities before the realm costs gold
The alphabet	600	Your trade deals bring twice the gold

Each is worth legacy (section 12): 10 points, 20 for the first people in the world to set it down. Help → Clay Tablets has a page on each.

12. Culture and legacy

Legacy points are what a people leaves behind. They are yours for good, whatever becomes of your cities, and they count in the score and decide the **legacy victory**.

Source	Legacy
A temple	3 when built
A city building (a temple too)	1 every 32 turns, while you hold its city (see below)
A wonder	20
A clay tablet	10 (20 if the first in the world)
Purple dye, owned or traded for	1 every 16 turns

City buildings

Each city can have one of each. **They add to the legacy of whoever holds the city, every 32 turns, for as long as they stand**, so the earlier they are built the more they leave — the way to a hegemony as well as to a legacy victory. Short of gold for the upkeep, one is sold.

Building	Cost	Upkeep	Legacy every 32 turns	Also
Temple	40	1	1	3 legacy when built
Stele	30	none	1, 2 while at war with a people	
Edubba (scribal school)	60	1	1	a point of knowledge a turn, and a fifth of the scribes' pay more
Feasting Hall	60	2	2	

Help → City Buildings describes them.

The wonders

Each can be built once in the world, in one city. When one is built, everybody hears of it, and nobody else can build it. Its effect is for **whoever holds its city**.

Wonder	Cost	Effect
The Lion Gate of Mycenae	160	Every unit in its city defends twice as well
The Palace of Knossos	200	Half the corruption in all its holder's cities
The Temple of Karnak	200	Its holder's temples cost nothing and give twice the legacy
The Great Harbour of Ugarit	160	Its holder's ships have a move more (a coastal city only)

Help → Wonders describes them.

13. Barbarians

From about turn 30 bands of barbarian warriors appear on empty land far from anybody and attack whatever is near — units, cities, builders. They burn the cities they take. Keep a guard in every city; more on harder levels.

14. The calendar

The game runs from **1600 BC** to **1026 BC**: two years a turn until 1250 BC (turn 176), then one, **400 turns** in all. World → Score shows how many are left.

15. The Crisis

Around **1200 BC** the Late Bronze Age ends.

- **Omens.** About turn 200 a rumour of trouble in the west; at 215 a warning from another ruler; at **turn 226** the letter from Ugarit: *seven ships of the enemy came...*
- **The Sea Peoples.** From then on fleets of raiders — fierce fighters, attack 3 — come over the sea to the richest coastal cities, more and more often towards the end. They attack from their ships, land, and burn what they take.
- **Network fracture.** Raiders sink merchant ships, and the trade deals they carried lapse; lose the copper or tin you depended on, and bronze goes with it.
- **Shocks.** Droughts (dry land yields less food for a while), earthquakes (a city shrinks and loses an improvement), plague (the largest city loses a third of its people), and revolts (an unguarded city goes over to rebels).
- **Pleas.** Rulers who lose cities write to you for help that cannot come.

Coastal cities need more guards, merchant ships need escorts, and a treasury and a second source of copper and tin are worth more than ever.

The collapse

A computer people that loses its capital breaks apart: if it has three or more cities, its cities furthest from the largest — about a third of its people — rise in revolt and become rebel cities, barbarian-held, which keep a guard and can be taken. This can happen at any time, but is most likely in the Crisis.

16. The end: winning and losing

The game ends after **turn 400**, or when every other people has fallen, or when you have no cities and no units left.

The **score** of each people is:

- 1 point for each citizen,
- 2 for each city,
- 2 for each trade good it has,
- 3 for each trade deal,
- 10 for each vassal,
- 1 for every 200 gold,
- and its legacy points.

The outcome, judged in this order:

1. **Hegemony** — your people stands at the end with the highest score of all the peoples still standing.
2. **Legacy** — you have more legacy points than any other people, fallen or not. This victory can be won **posthumously**: even if your cities fall in the Collapse, what you built is remembered.
3. **Survival** — your people stands at the end. Many did not.
4. **Defeat** — your people has fallen, and others left more behind.

Game → Retire ends the game early, with the score as it stands. World → Score shows the table at any time.

17. Saving

There are ten places to save a game in, numbered 0 to 9. **Game → Save Game** lists them, each with its comment or "empty": pick one with the cursor keys and Return, its number, or the mouse, and type a comment to remember the game by. It starts as your leader, your people and the year ("Agamemnon - Mycenaeans - 1450 BC"); DEL rubs out, Return saves and Esc goes back to the list. A save in a place that holds one replaces it. **Load Saved Game** on the title screen, or **Game → Load Game** during a game, lists the same ten and picks up the one you choose; the game you were playing is lost unless you saved it. A save made by another version of the game is listed as "from another version" and cannot be loaded.

18. Some advice

- Found your first city at once, and a second and third soon: a settler needs a city of size 2.
- Keep a defender in every city, fortified. Barbarians come from turn 30.
- Builders: irrigate grassland and floodplain, mine hills, pasture horses and cattle, and join your cities with roads.
- Look for copper and tin early. If you lack one, trade for it.
- Trade with your neighbours, and keep the deals alive with merchant ships — escorted ones after 1200 BC.
- Pay your scribes a little every turn: the tablets add up.
- Build steles and temples early, and halls and edubbas in the larger cities: their legacy grows with every turn they stand.
- Before the Crisis, put more guards in your coastal cities, and keep some gold.